with Khrushchev had been ‘the roughest thing in my life’.[19] He reflected:

> I think he did it because of the Bay of Pigs. I think he thought that anyone who was so young and inexperienced as to get into that mess could be taken, and anyone who got into it, and didn’t see it through, had no guts. So he just beat the hell out of me. So I’ve got a terrible problem. If he thinks I’m inexperienced and have no guts, until we remove those ideas we won’t get anywhere with him. [20]

The President returned to Washington via London to see Harold Macmillan. The Prime Minister sent away his officials, cancelled their formal engagements, and took Kennedy off for a drink and a chat. Reflecting upon the President’s difficult encounter in Vienna, Macmillan recorded, ‘For the first time in his life Kennedy met a man who was impervious to his charm.’[21]

The Soviet and American leaders had incompatible agendas on Berlin, not only concerning outcomes, but on the urgency with which the problem needed addressing. In early July Khrushchev announced he had halted plans to demobilise over a million troops, citing reports that Kennedy was about to significantly increase US defence spending. The Soviet defence budget would be increased by a third.[22]

In February 1961 Kennedy had appointed the formidable Dean Acheson to head a task force on Berlin. Truman’s former Secretary of State had been a pivotal figure in the onset of the Cold War. Over Berlin in 1961 and Cuba in 1962, he pressed for confrontation with Moscow, and in the missile crisis he became one of the ‘hawks’ who favoured military action against the Soviet missiles. At the end of June 1961 Acheson presented Kennedy with a stark analysis of the Berlin problem and provided recommendations about how to confront and deter Moscow: Kennedy should declare a national emergency and call-up reserves; order a rapid build-up of US nuclear and conventional forces; and send an additional two or three divisions to West Germany. If the Soviets threatened West Berlin’s autonomy, an airlift on the lines of 1948 should be organised. If Moscow sought to prevent this, the